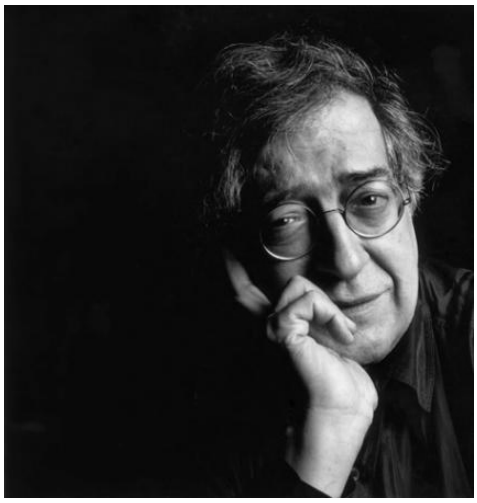
interconnection (2025)

for electronic track and six instruments



introduction

Luciano Berio's music is hard to categorise. He interacted with much of the post-war avant-garde—the serial music of Dallapicolla; Boulez and Stockhausen at the Darmstadt school; the electroacoustic innovations he encountered in visits to the USA; and the indeterminacy of Cage and Ives. His inspirations also lay beyond music—in the modernist literature of Joyce and Beckett, philosophy of Ernst Bloch, structuralist anthropology of Lévi-Strauss, and the works of Italian intellectual figures such as Umberto Eco and Edoardo Sanguineti. Above all, Berio was captivated by the human voice. His lifelong exploration of its expressive potential—sparked by his collaboration with his first wife, Cathy Berberian—runs as a connecting thread through early works like *Sequenza III* and *Omaggio a Joyce*, to later large-scale choral and operatic works.

The concept and structure of this piece is inspired by the third movement of Berio's 1968 masterpiece *Sinfonia*, which he described as unfolding along two narratives: the Scherzo from Mahler's Second Symphony and a continuous solo tenor voice. From this framework emerges a dense web of musical, literary, and historical allusions.

This piece centres on a continuous vocal stream which consists of archival recordings of Berio, voices from his personal or artistic circle such as Berberian, Eco, Chailly, Lévi-Strauss, Stravinsky, excerpts from his vocal works, readings of Joyce, and recordings from historical events such as the May '68 protests and Mussolini's speeches. The voices often overlap and interweave, shifting in

intelligibility, as a nod to the stream-of-consciousness modernist writing that *Sinfonia* seems to musically depict.

The accompanying music, like in *Sinfonia*, forms a collage of quotations which interact and respond to what the voices are saying. It draws on works by composers including Dallapiccola, Stockhausen, Mahler, Stravinsky, Berg, Cage, Schubert, and Berio himself. The piece then comprises six sections, each depicting a different period in Berio's creative development.

Berio saw creativity as a process of transcription—a musical work was never truly finished, always open to reinterpretation through not only further performances but also further compositions. Thus, he often reworked his own music, seen in his *Chemins* series. In *Rendering,* a "restoration" of Schubert's unfinished Tenth Symphony, Berio fills the empty spaces between the sketches with a distant, alien soundworld that intermingles with Schubert's music, which, in a *tratteggio*-like fashion, embraces rather than hides the damage which time has done. His use of quotation in *Sinfonia*, then, similarly rejects the modernist search for a new, cohesive language free from the musical traditions of the past, embracing instead the fragmented and pluralist aesthetic of a newly emerging postmodernism.

In 1972, Berio returned from the USA to an Italy ravaged by the political and social turmoil of the so-called 'Years of Lead' (1968-88). Two years later, he began composing *Coro,* a complex exploration of the relationship between voice and instrument, text and music, using a multilingual patchwork of folk songs from across the world. Yet, as a tribute to the tragedy that was unfolding in his country, the piece is also fiercely passionate and humane, with its haunting line from Pablo Neruda, "Come and see the blood in the streets." In some ways, *Coro* encapsulates the essence of Berio's music—as multilayered as the human experience, and intrinsically connected to both itself and to the vast network of history of which he was so acutely aware. Music, for Berio, was a living, evolving dialogue, carrying with it both the reverberations of the past and implications for the future. This piece is dedicated to a composer who left behind perhaps the most interconnected body of music ever written.

description

The six, biographically organised, sections connect fluidly and are not marked in the score. The content, however, makes clear the point by which the transitions have occurred, if not the precise moment of that occurrence.

I. musical prison

This section portrays Berio's experience of growing up in a musical family in Oneglia, a remote province in an artistically stifling Italy (quoting a Prelude and Fugue by his father, Ernesto Berio), the

passing by of WW2, and his eventual discovery of the music of Luigi Dallapiccola, who would become a major point of both musical and spiritual reference for Berio through his melodic approach to serialism and his politically conscious music. Based on a three-note melodic cell F-E-C#, from Dallapiccola's opera *Il Prigioniero* ("The Prisoner"), the music then shifts to quote Berio's *Chamber Music*, a setting of Joyce's poem, which he wrote as a response to Dallapiccola's musical idiom.

II. I felt I was walking in a kind of new land

Opening with extracts from *Sequenza III for voice,* this section introduces a new chapter in Berio's creative development starting from his interest in the human voice, his visits to the USA and the Darmstadt School in West Germany in the early 1950s which introduced him to electroacoustic music, and his joint establishment of the experimental electronic faculty Studio di fonologia musicale in Milan in 1955. Recordings of electronic music that Berio encountered by Stockhausen, Ussachevsky and Cage are combined with a reading of Joyce's poem *At That Hour* and Berio's own *Omaggio a Joyce*, using text from *Sirens* in *Ulysses,* which was revolutionary in its liberation of meaning from words, and its synthesis of poetry, technology and music.

III. cathy

This section celebrates the creative collaboration between Berio and mezzosoprano Cathy Berberian—the accompanying music is *Loosin Yelav* from *Folk Songs*, a song cycle which he wrote in tribute to Berberian's voice. It also depicts Berio's gradual disillusionment with electronic music, by opening with extracts from his electroacoustic work *Visage*, and ending with *Circles,* a purely acoustic experimentation of the voice through the poems of E.E. Cummings.

IV. self-portrait

The third movement of Berio's *Sinfonia* serves as the basis of this section—the music which the live ensemble plays is based on the Mahler Scherzo, layered with musical quotations from Stravinsky, Berlioz, Berg and Schubert. This music then interacts with the 1969 World Premiere recording of *Sinfonia,* with melodies being repeated and delayed to further blur a sense of time, meaning and understanding. Yet as fragmented and disjointed as it is, this section also highlights how Berio thought of his work as a "documentary", and a surprisingly personal one: a journey through his own inherited musical traditions and an attempt to understand them, to "find unity among very different things".

V. the smallest detail

This section focuses on Berio's later solo works for the piano, namely *Erdenklavier* and *Wasserklavier* from his *Six Encores for Piano,* and his *Sonata for Piano* written in 2000. Far removed from the exuberant quality of his work in the 60s, the two encores are connected through elemental themes of water and earth. Berio talks briefly of his home in Radicondoli, Italy, to which he retreated after

decades in the USA, and of “roots”, highlighting his fascination with folk material and “the smallest detail, in connection with the larger world.”

VI. the past is not a prison

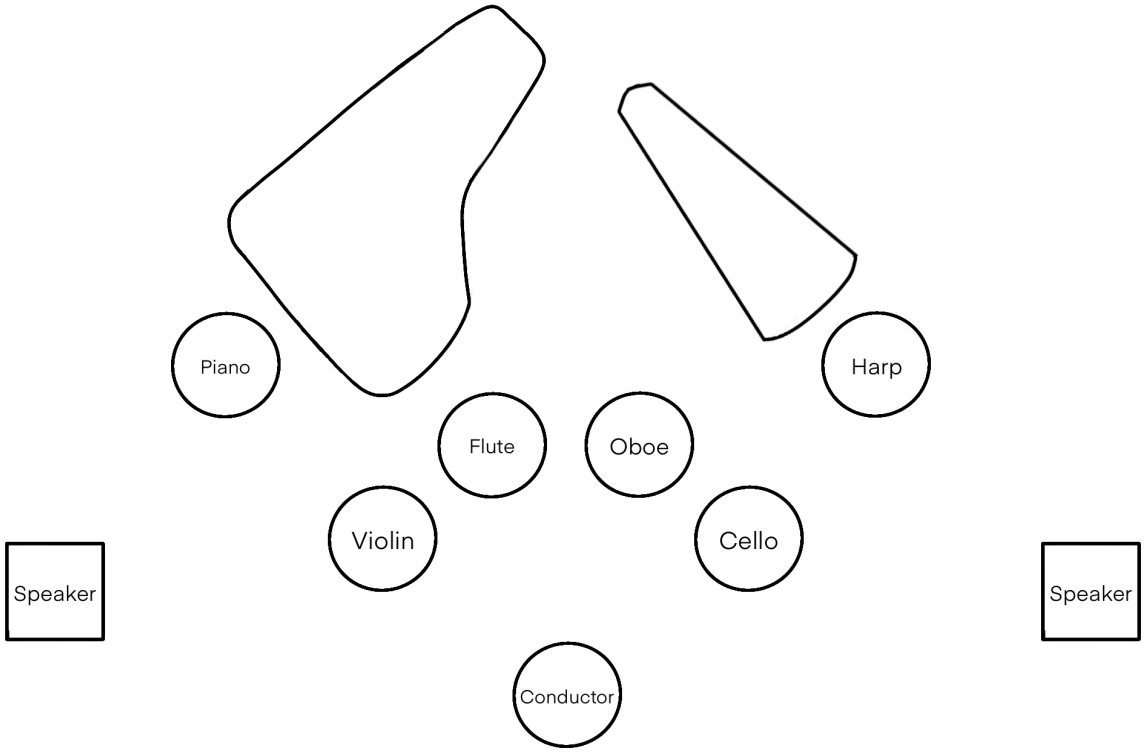
The second movement of *Coro* runs throughout this section, with the live ensemble echoing the electronic track and playing fragments of melodies from the first movement, *Today is mine*. Berio speaks of his relationship with history and how he sees it as a source of continual exploration and inspiration. The third movement of *Sinfonia* then returns as Eco talks of the connections between Berio and the contemporary world. The piece ends as a palimpsest of previous recordings of *Sinfonia*, as each tenor voice thanks different conductors who have recorded it throughout history.

performance notes

The live players should never overpower the electronic track, or vice versa. Where possible, the performers should strive for blending of their acoustic sound to the electronic track. The audio system should support stereo panning.

An assistant will be needed to start the audio track. The extensive timestamps marked in the score will aid the conductor in coordinating the live ensemble with the track.

The marked time always corresponds to the downbeat of the bar, unless otherwise shown.



sources

Works are listed in order of appearance in the piece.

vocal

Luciano Berio - A Contemporary Maestro (2000) - dir. Reuven Hecker
Il Duce (1937) - Mussolini speaking in Palermo Harbour
Luciano Berio, Interview (1972) - interview with Hans Heg for the Holland Festival
Cathy Berberian reading Sirens - unedited vocal sample from *Air Wars* by Crystal Castle (2007)
At That Hour, James Joyce - reading by Ole Irenaeus Wieroed
Cathy Berberian talking, rehearsing, singing, laughing, explaining (1979) - Fragments from a Dutch radio show
Music is the Air I Breathe (1997) - dir. Carrie de Swaan, on the life of Cathy Berberian
Voyage to Cythera (1999) - dir. Frank Scheffer
A Conversation with Igor Stravinsky (1957) - from *The Wisdom Series* by the National Broadcasting Company
Les leçons des peuples amérindiens selon Claude Lévi-Strauss (1991) - Interview on France 3
Paris May 1968 Student Protests - archival footage from DiFilm

musical

Sonic Contours (1952) - Luening & Ussachevsky
Sequenza III for female voice (1958) - Berio, performed by Cathy Berberian
Imaginary Landscape No.1 (1939) - Cage
Gesang der Jünglinge (1955) - Stockhausen
Thema - Omaggio a Joyce (1958) - Berio
Visage for tape (1961) - Berio
Circles (1960) - Berio
Sinfonia, movement 3 (1968) - world premiere recording by New York Philharmonic, conducted by Luciano Berio, 1969
Coro, movement 2 *"Venid a ver"* (1974-6) - Berio
Sinfonia, movement 3 (1968) -

Orchestra of the Academy of Santa Cecilia, Rome, conducted by Antonio Pappano, 2007
CBSO, conducted by Simon Rattle, 1987
Czech Philharmonic, conducted by Semyon Bychkov, 2018
Gothenburg Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Péter Eötvös, 2005
Chicago Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Pierre Boulez, 1995
Royal Concertgebouw Orchestra, conducted by Ed Spanjaard, 2010
Stony Brook Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Eduardo Leandro, 2016
UC Davis Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Christian Baldini, 2015
Hamburg Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Markus Stenz, 2000